

Psalms 39

The Frailty of Life

Lord, make me to know mine end

KJV · Standalone study handout

1 · THE WORD (KJV)

- 1 *I said, I will take heed to my ways, that I sin not with my tongue: I will keep my mouth with a bridle, while the wicked is before me.*
- 2 *I was dumb with silence, I held my peace, even from good; and my sorrow was stirred.*
- 3 *My heart was hot within me, while I was musing the fire burned: then spake I with my tongue,*
- 4 *LORD, make me to know mine end, and the measure of my days, what it is; that I may know how frail I am.*
- 5 *Behold, thou hast made my days as an handbreadth; and mine age is as nothing before thee: verily every man at his best state is altogether vanity. Selah.*
- 6 *Surely every man walketh in a vain shew: surely they are disquieted in vain: he heapeth up riches, and knoweth not who shall gather them.*
- 7 *And now, Lord, what wait I for? my hope is in thee.*
- 8 *Deliver me from all my transgressions: make me not the reproach of the foolish.*
- 9 *I was dumb, I opened not my mouth; because thou didst it.*
- 10 *Remove thy stroke away from me: I am consumed by the blow of thine hand.*
- 11 *When thou with rebukes dost correct man for iniquity, thou makest his beauty to consume away like a moth: surely every man is vanity. Selah.*
- 12 *Hear my prayer, O LORD, and give ear unto my cry; hold not thy peace at my tears: for I am a stranger with thee, and a sojourner, as all my fathers were.*
- 13 *O spare me, that I may recover strength, before I go hence, and be no more.*

2 · CONTEXT

David resolves to guard his tongue, especially in front of the wicked, but the inward pressure of unspoken frustration eventually forces him to speak—turning into a meditation on the brevity and vanity of human life: “mine age is as nothing before thee... every man at his best state is altogether vanity.” The psalm closes with a plea for God to spare him before he departs this life entirely. Henry notes that silence under provocation is wise but not infinite; here restrained frustration is redirected into prayerful perspective on mortality rather than either venting or despair.

3 · VERSE-BY-VERSE COMMENTARY

The notes below cover the whole chapter in one place—read with the KJV text above.

Verse 1-3

David resolves to keep watch over his ways and bridle his tongue, especially before the wicked; but keeping silent even from good things increased his pain until his heart grew hot within him and, like a fire, forced him to speak.

Verse 4-6

He asks the Lord to make him know his end and the measure of his days, to see how frail he is; his days are as mere handbreadths, his age as nothing before God, every man at his best state altogether vanity. Man walks in a mere show, is disquieted in vain, and heaps up riches not knowing who will gather them.

Verse 7-9

Turning to hope: “And now, Lord, what wait I for? my hope is in thee.” He asks to be delivered from his transgressions and not made the reproach of fools, and he stays silent because it is God who has done this to him.

Verse 10-11

He asks God to remove His stroke, for he is consumed by the blow of His hand; when God rebukes a person for iniquity, their beauty consumes away like a moth—every man is vanity.

Verse 12-13

A final plea: hear my prayer, give ear to my cry, be not silent at my tears, for I am a stranger and sojourner as all my fathers were. “O spare me, that I may recover strength, before I go hence, and be no more.”

4 · MEANING & APPLICATION

Meaning.

Recognizing life’s brevity is not meant to produce despair but a clearer hope placed in God rather than in wealth, status, or the illusion of permanence. Even restrained, half-suppressed frustration can become honest, fruitful prayer when it is finally spoken to God rather than only bottled up or only vented at others.

Application for life today.

When frustration builds toward those around you, consider whether—like David—you need to bring it to God directly rather than either exploding at people or stewing in silence indefinitely. Let verse 4’s prayer (“make me to know mine end”) become a periodic check on what you are actually living for. Ask what “riches” or plans you are quietly heaping up without asking who will gather them (v. 6).

5 · REFLECT & RESPOND

Write your answers in the space below. There are no “right length” answers—honesty before God is the aim.

1. What frustration have you been keeping bridled that might need, like David’s, to become honest prayer rather than continued silence?

2. How does praying “Lord, make me to know mine end” (v. 4) change your view of a current long-term plan or ambition?

3. Where is your hope currently resting—in something as fleeting as “vanity,” or explicitly “in thee” (v. 7) as David chooses?

Name: _____ Date: _____ Group / Church: _____

Sources: King James Version (public domain); Matthew Henry, Commentary on the Whole Bible (themes summarized); Expository themes consistent with MacArthur Study Bible tradition (paraphrased, not quoted). Scripture: King James Version (public domain).